

Summary: Postmodernism (Modernism) & Social Justice

Social Justice

Social justice refers to a political and philosophical theory that focuses on the idea of fairness in relations between individuals in society and equal access to opportunities, wealth and social rights.

Social Justice – Explained video link:

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-C_onGQhiqE

Modernism and Postmodernism are two important movements in the history of art, literature, and culture. In a South African educational context, Modernism refers to the artistic and cultural movement that emerged in the early 20th century, characterized by a focus on individualism, rationality, and progress. This movement aimed to break away from traditional forms of art and literature and emphasized the importance of experimentation and innovation.

Postmodernism emerged in the late 20th century as a response to Modernism. It is characterized by a rejection of fixed meanings and grand narratives, and an emphasis on plurality, diversity, and hybridity. In a South African educational context, Postmodernism has been influential in challenging traditional power structures and promoting diversity and inclusivity.

Overall, both Modernism and Postmodernism have had a significant impact on South African culture and education, shaping the way we think about art, literature, and society.

Modernism

Modernism is based on science and the scientific method. Modernism places a strong emphasis on logic, progress, and the acceptance of universal truths. It promotes standardized education and the application of scientific approaches to problem-solving. Modernism is based on science and the scientific method. Ironically, as a science becomes more and more managed, it becomes less scientific and more technological. However, postmodernists suggest that science (and management) is just another meta-narrative and should have no more of a priority than any other meta-narrative. Postmodernists can create new meta-narratives – often they create narratives that are pastiches of the old and the new. We see

premodern, modern and postmodern occurring simultaneously and harmoniously together – in architecture, in business, in culture and yes, in the academy. (Bergquist, 1993)

Postmodernism

Some of the tenets of postmodernism have resulted in a paradigm shift in the whole education methodology. Embracing diversity, subjectivity, and cultural relativism, postmodernism rejects the notion of universal truths. Postmodernism promotes a more open-minded strategy that acknowledges students' varied cultural upbringings and life experiences in the South African educational setting. Postmodernism emphasizes critical thinking, authority-questioning, and the dismantling of dominant narratives while Modernism emphasizes objective knowledge and linear thinking.

Postmodernism encourages educators in South African educational settings to consider various viewpoints and involve students in critical debates about social issues and power relations. There is a general shift from a teacher centred classroom to a student centred one.

Traditionally, a learner was viewed as an empty slate. All knowledge was supposed to come from the teacher. Learning by heart was at the core of the teaching methodology. Rather than 'drill & practice' direct style, traditional learning, replicating the knowledge taught in a copy / identical fashion, attention shifts to establishing learning environments conducive to children constructing their knowledge. Critics to this system argued that learners cannot be empty slates to be filled by the teacher. Even when a learner steps in the school compound for the first time, he or she should not be viewed as being completely blank. At least he or she knows something which needs to be sharpened or built on. A student-centred classroom involves opportunities for social interaction, independent investigations and study and the expression of creativity as well as provision for different learning styles. There are students who create knowledge and are no longer forced to bow to the subjugation of traditional objective knowledge.

The postmodern approach recognizes that knowledge can both be discovered and constructed. Stimulating and affirming creativity in students is important in constructing knowledge and values, particularly if diverse viewpoints are encouraged. The student-centred approach considers what is known as multiple intelligences. The teaching methodology is formulated in such a way that different learning styles of learners are accommodated. In the learners' social realm, the postmodern view emphasizes tolerance and respect for other cultures. In a school setting where there are students from diverse backgrounds, acknowledging and celebrating other people's culture is encouraged.

Examples:

- Students are encouraged to form nature clubs where they learn the importance of a good and clean environment as well as how to take good care of it.
- In language, there has been a general shift towards gender inclusive speech and politically correct expressions.
- Textbooks and media reports are now gender sensitive and cognizant of the fact that biased gender coverage is both oppressive and discriminative.

Prescribed textbook - Selection of chapters for application (link with examples provided above and on the UTEW221 V Resources):

- 4. Practicing multicultural education in the classroom.
- 5. Parental involvement to enhance learner performance.
- 6. School decline: causes, effects, and ways of minimizing the effects.